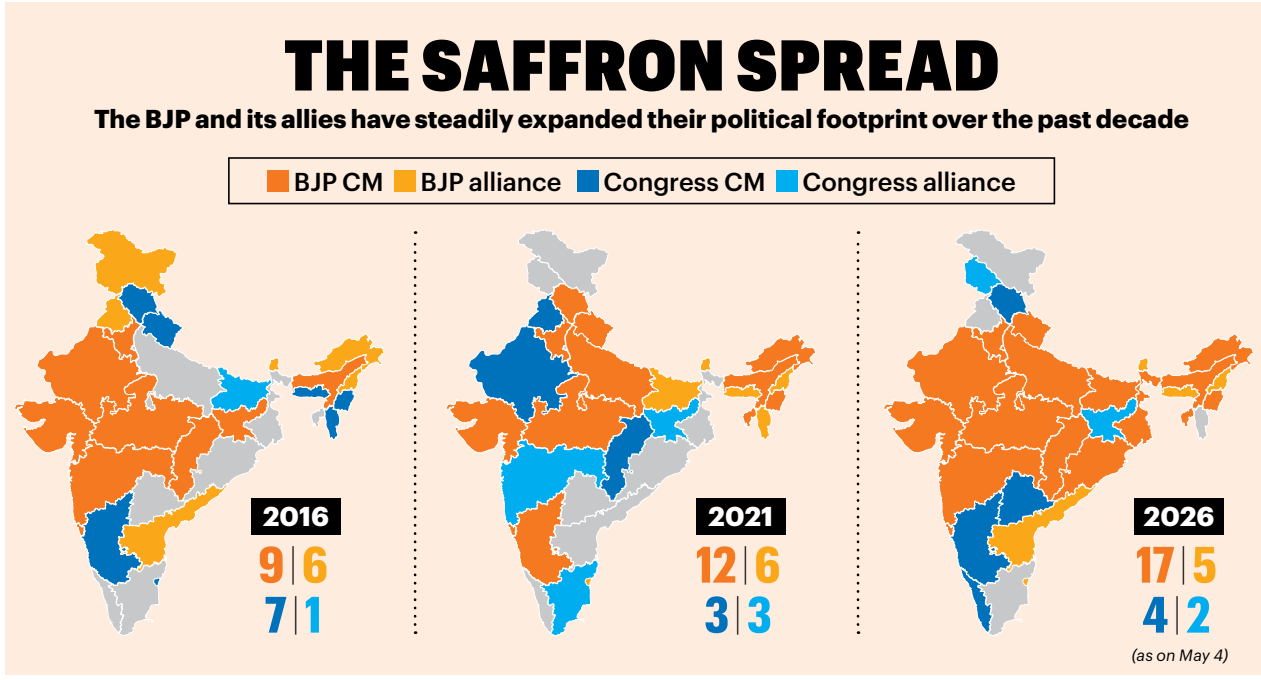


central to the BJP's strategy.

The groundwork for this mobilisation was laid not merely in rallies but through a carefully choreographed *sant pravas*—public appearances by Hindu seers designed to spiritually legitimise what was, in effect, a political mission. The Sangh and its affiliates also leveraged the regime change in Bangladesh in August 2024 and the reported attacks on the Hindu minority there to consolidate the Hindu vote. Shah's call to "detect, delete and deport" alleged infiltrators appeared to resonate with voters, packaging Hindutva not as ideology but as a question of survival. As a result, nearly 65 per cent of Hindu votes reportedly consolidated in the BJP's favour.

Split and Conquer

When it came to fragmenting Mamata's substantial Muslim support base, the BJP adopted a multi-pronged strategy. Bengal's Muslim population is regionally concentrated, forming a majority in districts such as Murshidabad (66 per cent), Malda (51 per cent) and Uttar Dinajpur (nearly 50 per cent), while remaining a decisive bloc in districts like South 24 Parganas (35 per cent), Nadia (around 27 per cent) and North 24 Parganas (about 25 per cent). A key factor here was the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls by the Election Commission of India. The process reduced the voter list from 76,637,529 to 68,251,002, including 2.7 million names, many from Muslim-dominated districts, kept in suspension by the Supreme Court. Combined with visible discontent towards the TMC among sections of the Muslim community, this created electoral openings for the BJP.

The party's strategy was to reshape the electoral balance around these Muslim concentrations through two parallel moves. First, it sought to align Hindu votes across caste lines, particularly among SC, ST and OBC communities that together form 35-40 per cent of the electorate in many constituencies. In belts like Birbhum, Nadia and North 24 Parganas, this involved targeted outreach to Namasudra Dalits, Rajbongshis, tribal groups and agrarian OBCs, along with welfare messaging and representation in local leadership structures.

The deletion of over 9.1 million names in the EC's special intensive revision of electoral rolls and discontent among sections of Muslims created further openings for the BJP

The BJP's second approach was to capitalise on fragmentation within the Opposition space in these regions. While Mamata continued to command overwhelming Muslim support, the Congress and the Left still retained a 5-10 per cent vote share in several minority-dominated seats. According to the BJP's internal assessment, even a 5-7 per cent split in minority votes among the Congress, the CPI(M)-led Left, the Indian Secular Front and the All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen could neutralise the consolidation that had powered the TMC in 2021. A partial "U-turn" and "surrender" on the Waqf amendment bill and slapdash courtship through hasty but "lazy" OBC classifications angered some Muslim segments. The fragmentation of the Muslim vote was a natural corollary.

Simultaneously, the BJP worked toward consolidating the non-minority vote beyond the 50-55 per cent threshold. Much of this strategy focused on securing OBC support through promised